FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

THE SHE LIST
UNDER 50

Fifty years of INDIA TODAY. While India enters its 80th year of Independence. It is the world's largest democracy but women hold barely 13.8 per cent seats in the Lok Sabha. Female voters make up 49 per cent of the electorate. They have out-voted men in two consecutive general elections. They are in every meaningful sense equal participants in the democratic exercise. What they are not is equal beneficiaries. The 2023 Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam became law to correct this old skew in political representation. A third of the Lok Sabha seats will be reserved for women. It is an overdue correction and Panchayati Raj experience over 33 years tells us that affirmative action of this kind actually works. There are today 1.45 million elected women representatives in village institutions across India. That process has been truly transformative. Sarpanch Dolly has created a quasi-judicial mechanism in her Sadipur village in Bihar so that locals do not have to approach the courts for dispute resolution. In Rajasthan's Lambi Ahir village, the *ghaghra*-clad sarpanch Neeru Yadav has set up an entire hockey training ecosystem for girls, overcoming stiff opposition and centuries of stifling patriarchy. They symbolise what can happen when women are given the space and chance to lead.



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As INDIA TODAY completes 50 years of its publication, this Independence Day special issue is our tribute to that possibility. We are calling it the 'She List: 50 under 50'. Fifty self-made women under the age of 50 who represent what Indian women are capable of when the odds, though rarely removed, are at least partially navigated. The selection criteria are deliberate. This is not the place to look for a rich heiress, a big corporate honcho's wife or a nepo kid from Bollywood. These women came up by dint of their own effort, their ingenuity, their insistence on altering the status quo. We have kept the cutoff age at 50, acknowledging the time it takes for most women to make the lonely trek uphill, against odds. This list presents a gallery of role models for the nearly 560 million women under 50 in India, who form 78 per cent of the country's female population. We exclude those affiliated to political parties. That is not to devalue that field but it's complicated to make a fair assessment of personal achievement and empowerment there. We have chosen five categories: entrepreneurs, innovators, professionals, artists and sportswomen.

These 50 women are the face of representation beyond politics. For them, freedom means economic independence, an ability to pursue and excel in professional opportunities, and expressing themselves creatively, breaking the shackles that Indian society imposed historically. The life trajectory of Farzana Afridi typifies this. Going against their insular social milieu in Bihar, her father encouraged her to pursue higher studies. She became the first in her family to obtain a PhD from a foreign university. Now a professor at the Indian Statistical Institute, Afridi's pathbreaking research on women's economic empowerment has shaped public policy in India in the past decade. As she points out, "Young women in India have to remain single-minded in their focus and seize opportunities that provide a sense of purpose beyond traditional expectations. A woman's life never stops being challenging, mine certainly hasn't."

Afridi is right. Though India's gender indices have improved vastly since Independence, we must temper our elation in the face of chastening numbers. Women are still born unequal. Literally. At 939 females to 1,000 males, our sex ratio is among the lowest in the world. The female literacy rate, at 74.9 per cent, still leaves out a full one-fourth—and lags behind men by nearly 13 points. Women make up only 5.21 per cent of CEOs in listed companies and commit only 40 per cent to the labour force, mostly in low-paying farm jobs. Crime against women remains a national shame, recording 1,200 cases every day. Campaigns such as Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao have made a difference but not enough. The recent Gen Z agitation was a social expression of those statistical gaps. The strong female participation reflects their dissatisfaction at the existing order.

Against this sobering backdrop, these stories reveal, uniformly, an inner determination to succeed. A scientist who shines the torch on how DNA repairs itself. A conservationist who modifies rural psychology as part of a dramatic species rescue. Two naval officers who circumnavigate the world. A fighter pilot. Hip-hop star Daiaphi Lamare aka Reble, who scored the foot-stomping number 'Main Aur Tu' in *Dhurandhar*, told us, "When I discovered music, I discovered confidence." Exceptional individuals can seem like exceptions. This list suggests they are not. They are the visible edge of a much larger shift happening across India, in small towns and metros, in the fields and factories and court rooms and laboratories, wherever Indian women are choosing to live on their own terms.

This special issue is our celebration of that choice, and of the fifty years this magazine has spent bearing witness to an India in the process of becoming what it promised to be.

Happy Independence Day.

(Aroon Purie)